

Psalms 121

My Help Cometh from the Lord

I will lift up mine eyes unto the hills, from whence cometh my help

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *I will lift up mine eyes unto the hills, from whence cometh my help.*
- 2 *My help cometh from the LORD, which made heaven and earth.*
- 3 *He will not suffer thy foot to be moved: he that keepeth thee will not slumber.*
- 4 *Behold, he that keepeth Israel shall neither slumber nor sleep.*
- 5 *The LORD is thy keeper: the LORD is thy shade upon thy right hand.*
- 6 *The sun shall not smite thee by day, nor the moon by night.*
- 7 *The LORD shall preserve thee from all evil: he shall preserve thy soul.*
- 8 *The LORD shall preserve thy going out and thy coming in from this time forth, and even for evermore.*

2 · CONTEXT

One of the most beloved Songs of Ascents, Psalm 121 pictures a pilgrim looking toward the hills surrounding Jerusalem—perhaps a source of both scenic comfort and real danger from bandits along the road—before redirecting confidence away from the hills themselves and onto their Maker. The psalm's repeated language of keeping, preserving, and not slumbering builds a sustained picture of a God whose watchfulness never lapses. Henry treats the shift from 'I' in verse 1 to a second voice answering with assurance in verses 3–8 as a kind of liturgical dialogue, encouragement offered from one worshiper to another along the road.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The psalm opens with the pilgrim's own gaze lifted toward the hills, asking directly from where help will come. The answer arrives immediately and decisively: help comes from the Lord, specifically identified as the maker of heaven and earth—help traced to its ultimate source rather than left to the hills themselves, however impressive.

Verse 3-4

A second voice, or a deepened resolve, answers with assurance: he will not allow your foot to be moved, and the one who keeps you will not slumber. The claim intensifies further—Israel's keeper neither slumbers nor sleeps, a watchfulness with no gaps, no shift changes, no moments of inattention.

Verse 5-6

The Lord is named directly as keeper, a shade at the right hand offering protection from the sun's heat by day—and, more strikingly, from the moon by night, covering even threats not obviously dangerous, extending care to every hour.

Verse 7-8

The promise widens to cover every kind of evil, preserving the soul itself, not merely physical safety. The closing assurance covers the whole of ordinary life—going out and coming in—promised from this time forward and forevermore, security extended across both daily movement and the entire span of time.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Genuine security is not found in scanning the landscape for signs of safety but in tracing help back to its actual source—the Maker of heaven and earth, whose watchfulness never lapses into slumber or sleep. This kind of care is not occasional or partial; it extends across day and night, going out and coming in, this moment and every moment still to come.

Application for life today.

When you find yourself anxiously scanning circumstances for reassurance, as the pilgrim scans the hills, practice redirecting that gaze specifically to God as the source of help, not merely to whatever looks currently stable. Let the psalm's insistence that God 'neither slumbers nor sleeps' (v. 4) address any fear that His attention to you might lapse or grow distracted. Apply verse 8's promise concretely to your own 'going out and coming in' today—your commute, your daily tasks, your ordinary movements—as covered by the same watchful care the psalm describes.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where are you currently looking to 'the hills'—circumstances, people, or plans—for the security that this psalm says can only be found in God as Maker (vv. 1–2)?

2. How does the assurance that God 'neither slumbers nor sleeps' (v. 4) address a specific fear you carry about His attention lapsing when you need Him most?

3. What would it look like to apply verse 8's promise—preserved in your 'going out and coming in'—to the actual, ordinary movements of your day today?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).